

The thing that really connected us? Being able to talk about our debt payoff journeys. Jen was blogging about how she and Travis were working to pay off \$78,000 of debt, while Eric and I were choosing nontraditional housing (full-time RV-ing) to put more money toward my student loan debt. Of course, during our St. Pete visit we both enjoyed the free champagne shots, hanging in the hot tub at the KOA where we parked, and catching a free outdoor movie by the water! But more than finding someone who was also interested in having fun without spending a lot of money, I found connection and community.

Jen became a safe place to ask questions about financial terms that previously seemed over my head, and because of her, I started caring about retirement investing. I've come to recognize that learning always happens in relationships. Infants learn from their caregivers, children from their teachers, professionals from their mentors, and in every other human interaction. We learn from each other, not in isolation.

Beyond what our friendship has offered to each other over the years, we have been blown away by the community built around *Frugal Friends*. While the idea of community is embedded in our podcast title, no one could have prepared us for the stories of life-changing moments listeners have experienced as the result of learning alongside us and engaging with each other online. There is true power and wealth to be found in relationships, beyond what can be enjoyed and discovered alone.

I first heard about the term “relational capital,” also called “social capital,” when interviewing permaculture expert Laura Oldanie on our podcast. We talked about how financial capital, aka money, is only one form of capital we use to acquire things, yet it's all we tend to focus on. When we say capital, we're not referring to superficial or manipulative metrics like “How many friends do you have?,” “How many likes and follows are you getting on the gram?,” or “How connected is your network?,” but rather the depth of connections formed with those in our neighborhoods, online, and among family and friend groups. As we make investments in our relationships and community, we experience increased benefit to all aspects of our lives. This relational capital should be tallied up with all the other forms of capital: material, intellectual, living, experiential, spiritual, cultural, and, finally, our financial capital. When we can value and invest in all of these areas, we will rarely go broke!